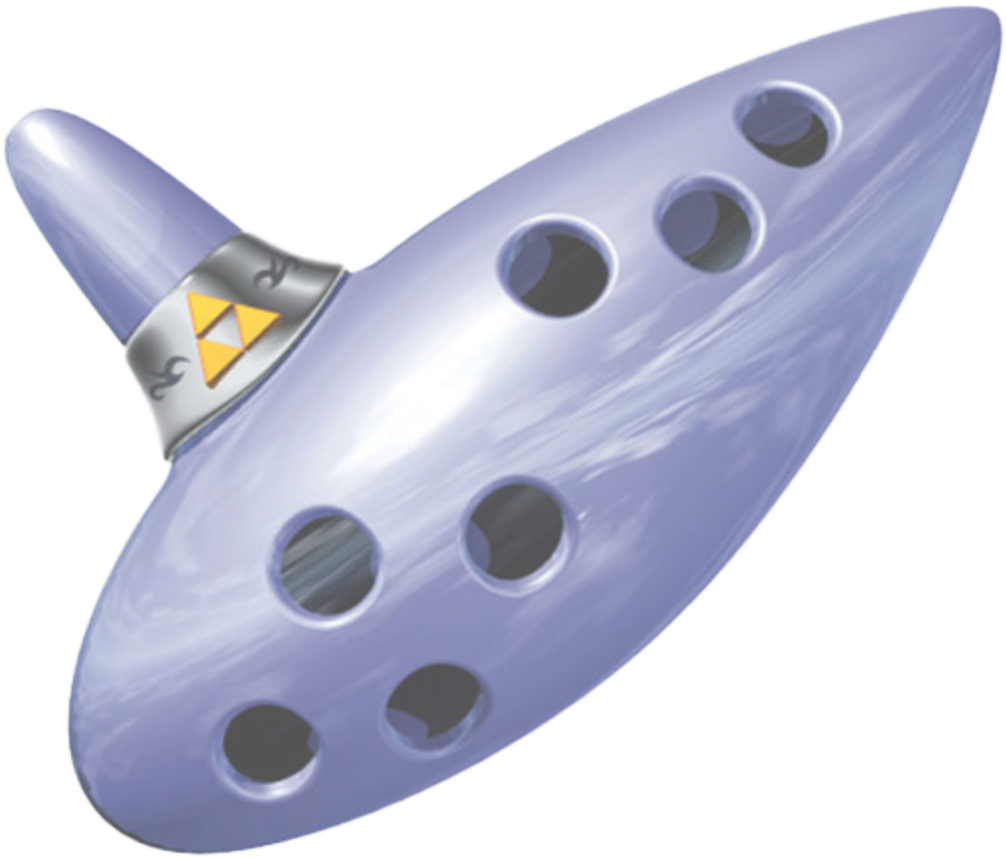


Trials of Light

Level Design Document



Overview

The Trials of Light continue the adventure of the Hero of Time. Once Link has defeated Bongo Bongo and Twinrova and completed the Shadow Temple and Spirit Temple, he will be prompted to return to the Temple of Time as in the original game. At the temple, Link will be met with Sheik who, rather than unveiling his identity as Princess Zelda, will instead implore the Hero of Time to complete the Trials of Light.

At the end of this dungeon, Link will bathe the Master Sword in the light of the golden goddesses, and will have an empowered version of the Master Sword to face Ganondorf. Once the Trials of Light are complete, Link will return to the main room of the Temple of Time, Princess Zelda will reveal herself, and the rest of the game will continue as usual.

Location

The Trials of Light is a mini-dungeon located underneath the Temple of Time. If Link stands at the pedestal of the Master Sword and plays Zelda's Lullaby on the Ocarina of Time, the surrounding platform will begin to descend. Before long, the player will be at the entrance of the Trials of Light mini-dungeon.



Length & Placement

This dungeon is comparable in length to the Ice Cavern and Bottom of the Well mini-dungeons. Similarly to how those two dungeons were smaller precursors to the Water Temple and Shadow Temple respectively, the Trials of Light dungeon is a smaller precursor in preparation for the final dungeon of the game: Ganon's Castle.

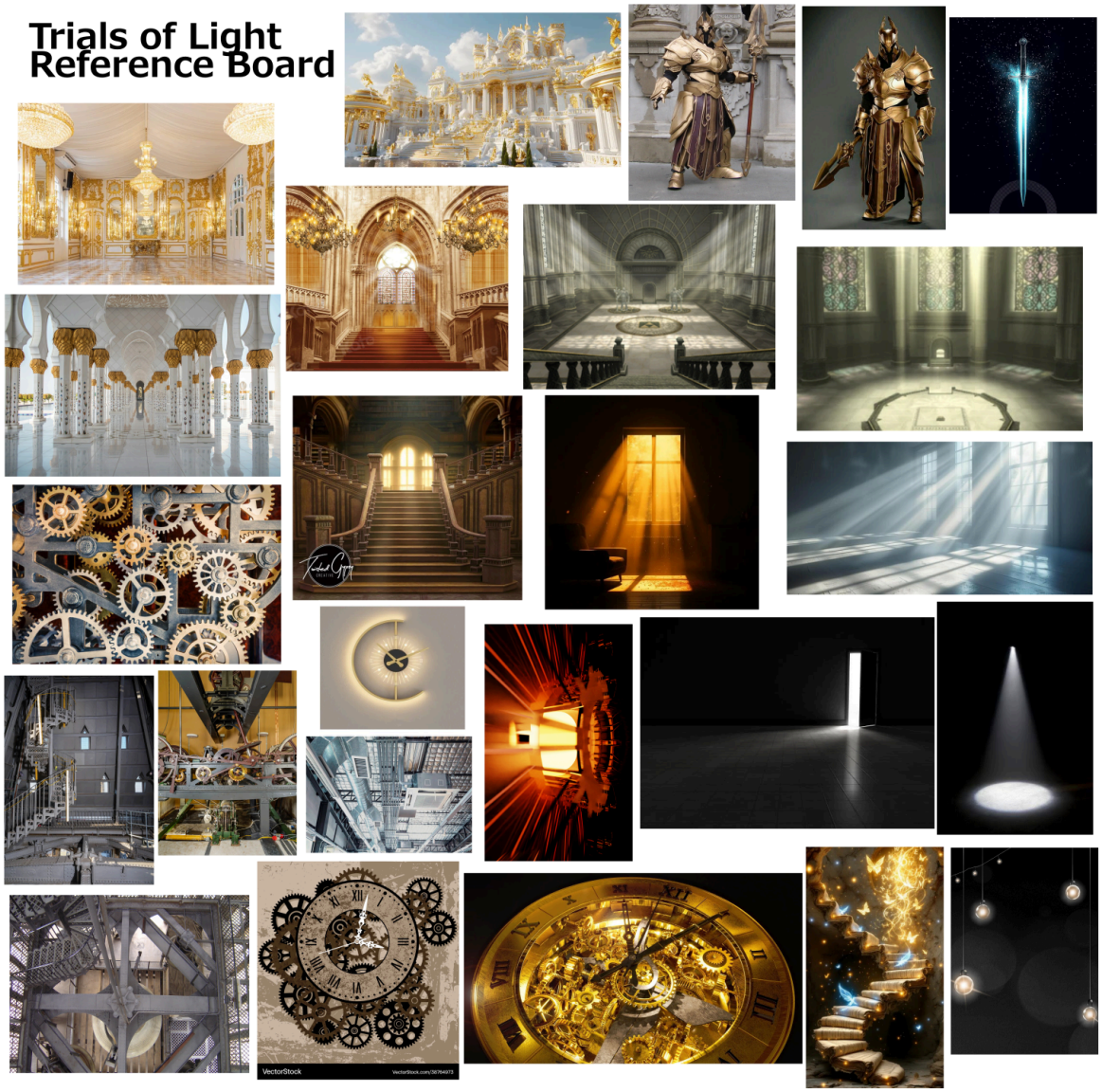
World Design

Architecture

The architecture of the dungeon will resemble the inner workings of a clock while portraying themes of overcoming darkness with light. This theme is meant to represent the unification of the Hero of Time and the Princess of Light in their quest to defeat the King of Evil.

The dungeon will contain a large clock-like centrepiece which controls the amount of divine light that shines into the temple. As the large clockhand of the centrepiece moves, more light will shine through (see Local Mechanics for details on how the clockhand moves).

Reference Board



Clockwork Aesthetic

- Use of gears, levers, clock hands, and other mechanical components
- Metallic materials for every structure
- Structures made up of several moving parts rather than singular static parts

Divine Light

- Parts of the level hidden in darkness until it is revealed by more light
- Player cannot interact with parts of the level that are hidden in darkness (no collision)
- Mystical pathways created from light
- Use of gold and white throughout

Global Mechanics

- Player can use the Fairy Bow to hit an eye switch to cause some kind of effect
- Player can use the Longshot to grapple onto targets or wooden objects
- Time Blocks will move or disappear when the Song of Time is played
- Certain blocks can be pushed or pulled
- Player can engage in combat using a Sword and Shield

Local Mechanics

- Hitting crystal switches causes blocks or walls to either move or appear
- Levers can be pushed or pulled to change the structure of the room
- Light rays can be reflected using the Mirror Shield
- Reflected light can be shone on a sun switch to cause some kind of effect
- The centrepiece have four levels of light transmission
- Playing Zelda's Lullaby at certain points will cause the large centrepiece clockhand to move to the next level, unveiling more divine light
- Divine light shining through the centrepiece will cause stairways and platforms to appear

Aesthetics

Sensation

Creates a sense of wonder and calm with the mystical visuals and the satisfying movements of the mechanical elements. The overall theme of divine light uncovering the darkness will also help create a sense of mystery and magnificence.

Challenge

The more intricate puzzles made up of several parts will provide a new challenge for the player and they will feel clever for deducing the solution and executing it with the necessary precision.

Fantasy

The player can truly immerse themselves into the role of the Hero of Time as they undergo trials set specifically for the hero. With the grandeur of both the clockwork aesthetic and the concept of divine light, alongside the end goal of powering up the Master Sword to defeat evil once and for all, the player will get a great sense of importance from this dungeon.

World Cohesion

Trial for the Hero

The Trials of Light is a dungeon created by the sages of old as a test for the wielder of the Master Sword. Its location beneath the Temple of Time, as well as the requirement of playing Zelda's Lullaby to access it, is meant to tie the Master Sword directly with the mission of the royal family of Hyrule. The use of Zelda's Lullaby fits cleanly into the established function of the world as the song is often used to reveal paths for the hero.

Additionally, with its visual aesthetic and local mechanics of the centrepiece, it is designed to feel like the mystical inner workings of the Temple of Time, connecting it to the story of the hero and established pivotal areas.

Many other games within the *Legend of Zelda* franchise include some means of upgrading the Master Sword or going through a specific trial to enhance it to its full power (A Link To The Past, Wind Waker, Breath Of The Wild, etc.). Therefore, including a trial here fits quite cleanly into what has been established in the franchise.

Light Temple



After pulling out the Master Sword for the first time and speaking with the sage of light, Rauru, the player is given the Light Medallion. This is the only medallion that is not directly linked to a temple of the same name. The Trials of Light taking the place of this "Light Temple" helps tie that aspect together.

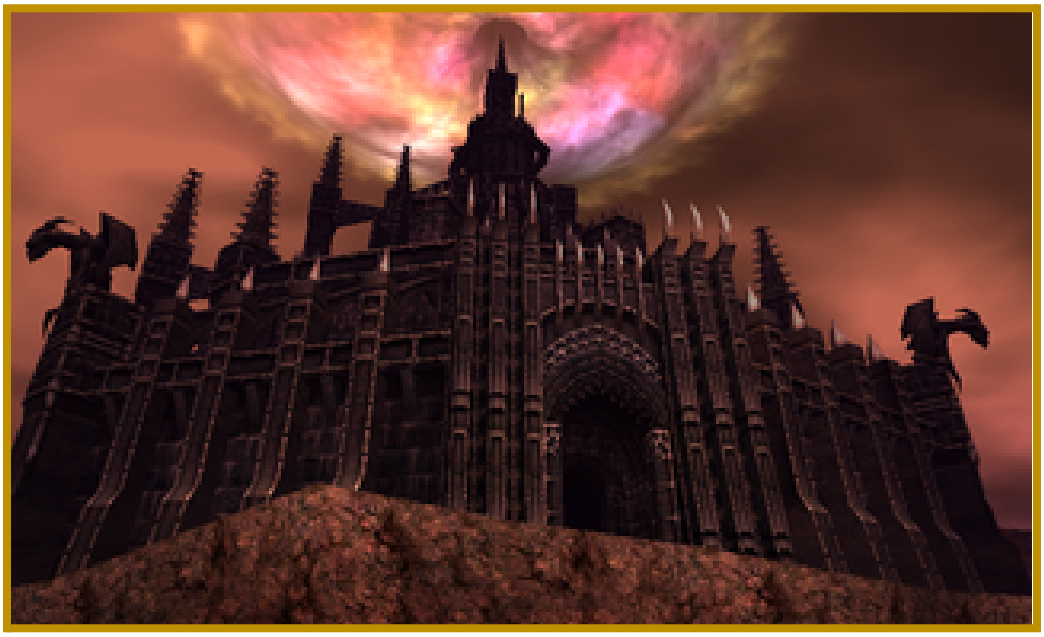
This also makes Link's journey as an adult come full circle. He receives the Light Medallion after first pulling out the Master Sword, and only after completing all five other temples and receiving their medallions can he enter the Trials of Light. Once this dungeon is complete, Link will have truly proven himself as the Hero of Time and is thus rewarded with the Master Sword at its full potential.

Final Preparation

Since the Trials of Light is a mini-dungeon set directly before Ganon's Castle, it is meant to provide a visual, narrative, and mechanical contrast to this final dungeon. The ways in which this mini-dungeon contrasts Ganon's Castle mechanically can be viewed in Design Goal.

With the gold and white colours and calmer mechanical aesthetic, this dungeon is meant to look pristine and sacred. There are little to no elements of destruction present in this dungeon. This is all to contrast Ganon's Castle with its more hectic and darker aesthetic. It utilizes reds and violets and has an air of magic that makes the building feel alive.

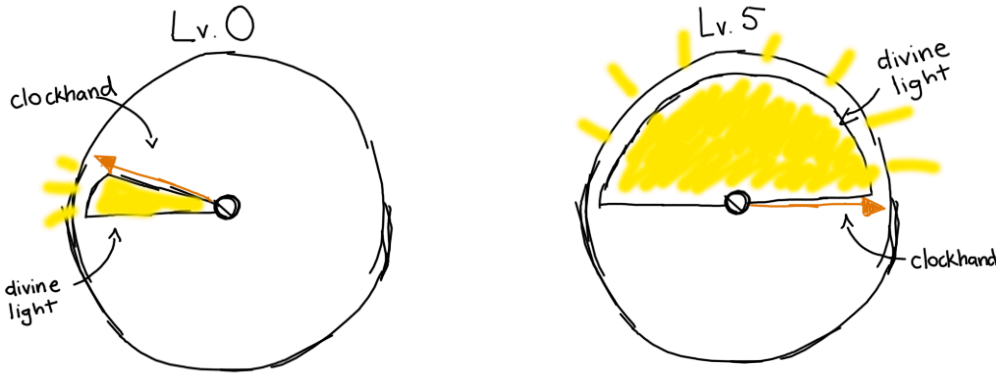
In terms of their roles within the world and story, the Trials of Light is a sacred place with the sole purpose of preparing the Hero of Time for his final mission. This mini-dungeon provides a culminating experience leading up to the climax that is Ganon's Castle. The final dungeon is the ultimate test of Link's strength and courage and provides an even more satisfying release after the Trials of Light dungeon is completed.



Objectives

The player's primary objective in this dungeon is to fully unveil the divine light by causing the centrepiece clockhand to move through all five of its levels. Once the divine light is fully transmitted through the centrepiece, the player can upgrade the Master Sword.

This objective is completed by solving four puzzle rooms around the dungeon, each one ending with a point where the player can play Zelda's Lullaby to cause the centrepiece clockhand to move up one level. The first and fourth rooms must be completed first and fourth respectively, but the second and third rooms can be completed in either order. The final level of the clockhand is attained by fighting a middle boss enemy known as the Golden Guardian. After the Golden Guardian is defeated, the player can play Zelda's Lullaby one final time and the centrepiece clockhand will move to its final position.



After the player enhances the Master Sword with the full power of the divine light, two more Golden Guardians will spawn. The player must defeat these two enemies before having officially completed the Trials of Light dungeon. These enemies are placed here to show the player's new strength with the enhanced Master Sword.

Design Goal

The goal of the Trials of Light dungeon is to provide a larger, more complex dungeon that is primarily focused on puzzles. This mini-dungeon is meant to be a culmination of the player's puzzle solving skills that have developed throughout the game. It also aims to lead up to Ganon's Castle by way of contrasting puzzle design.

The first half of Ganon's Castle is focused on smaller puzzles that contain one primary component, yet have complex solutions. These puzzles also include various external pressures that the player must deal with while solving the puzzles (enemies, hazards, time limits). The Trials of Light dungeon contains larger puzzles that contain several components to create a complex solution. To allow players to ease into more difficult puzzles, there are no external pressures from enemies or hazards while solving these puzzles.

Obstacles

Due to the nature of the dungeon being slowly uncovered as more divine light shines through the centrepiece, the primary obstacle blocking the player's progression is the remaining parts of the dungeon not being accessible or interactable due to not being visible. This obstacle is quickly overcome by solving the puzzle rooms or defeating the Golden Guardian.

Golden Guardian

The Golden Guardian is a new middle boss level enemy. It is similar to an Iron Knuckle in terms of size and strength. The Golden Guardian is a large soldier plated with golden armour wielding a silver broadsword and shield. It is functionally similar to a Stalfos in combat, and has the same health, attack damage, and attack speed as an Iron Knuckle.

The Golden Guardian will take 8 hits to kill with the Master Sword before the upgrade and will take 4 hits to kill with the Master Sword after the upgrade.

The Golden Guardian is the only enemy that is present in the Trials of Light. This is both to allow players to focus on the puzzles and combat separately and to demonstrate that this enemy was created by the sages as a test, as opposed to being created by Ganon.





Puzzle Types

- Pushing blocks
- Pushing levers to move parts of a room's structure
- Activating a floor switch with the player character or a block
- Hitting a crystal switch with a sword, arrow, or longshot
- Shoot eye switch with an arrow
- Grapple to targets using the longshot
- Shine light on sun switch using the mirror shield
- Play the Song of Time to cause a time block to move
- Play Zelda's Lullaby to move the centrepiece clockhand to the next level



Challenges

The Trials of Light dungeon is a puzzle-focused level which challenges the player's logic and reasoning capabilities. The puzzle rooms will mix various types of challenges to create puzzles where the player must consider every involved mechanic and take their time planning out the solution. These puzzles involve reconfiguring the structure of the room to match the mechanical theme of the dungeon.

Challenge Types

- **Platforming:** Challenge where the player needs to traverse various platforms to reach an end goal
- **Timing:** Challenge that requires an action to be executed at a precise time for success
- **Time Limit:** Challenge that requires a certain number of actions to be executed before a time limit runs out
- **Logic:** Challenge that involves reasoning to determine how multiple components work together in order to find a solution

Puzzle Types

- **Push Block:** Pushing or pulling a block into a desired location
- **Fairy Bow:** Shooting crystals or eye switches to activate different features
- **Longshot:** Grapple to various grapple points for traversal
- **Mirror Shield:** Reflect light to activate a sun switch
- **Song of Time:** Play the Song of Time next to a time block to cause it to move or disappear

Level Sections

Each of the four sections will have a specific set of challenge types and puzzle types that it incorporates to progressively test the player's skill with those mechanics.

Section 1
Challenge Types: Logic
Puzzle Types: Push Block, Mirror Shield, Song of Time

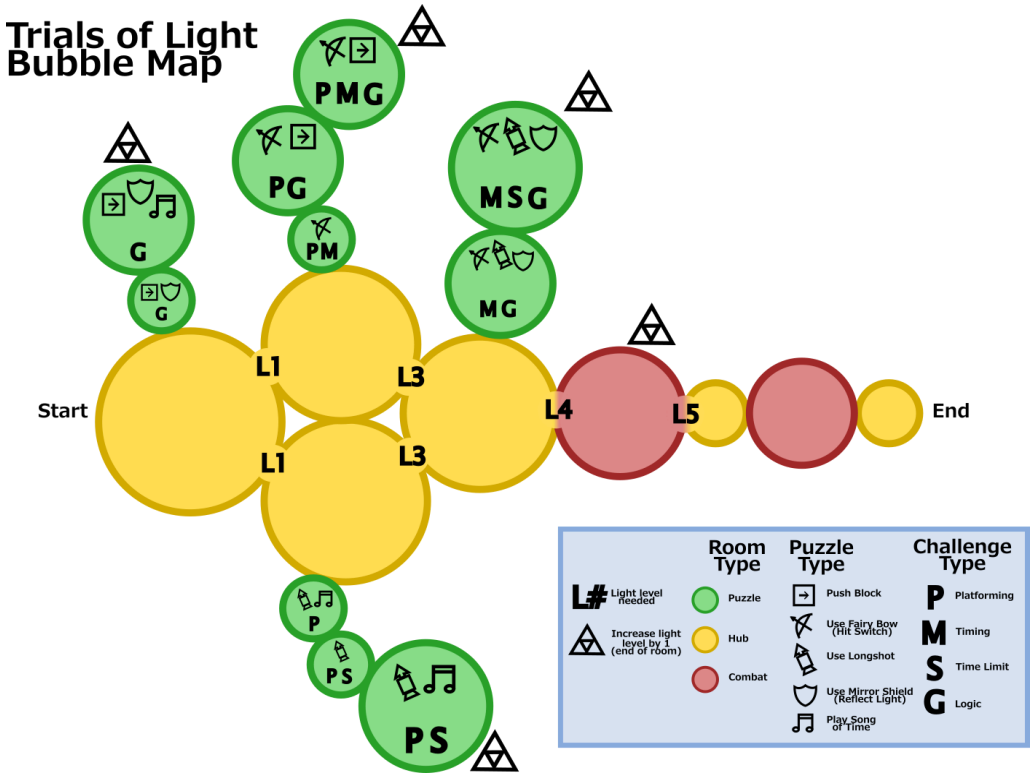
Section 2
Challenge Types: Platforming, Time Limit
Puzzle Types: Longshot, Song of Time

Section 3
Challenge Types: Platforming, Timing, Logic
Puzzle Types: Push Block, Fairy Bow

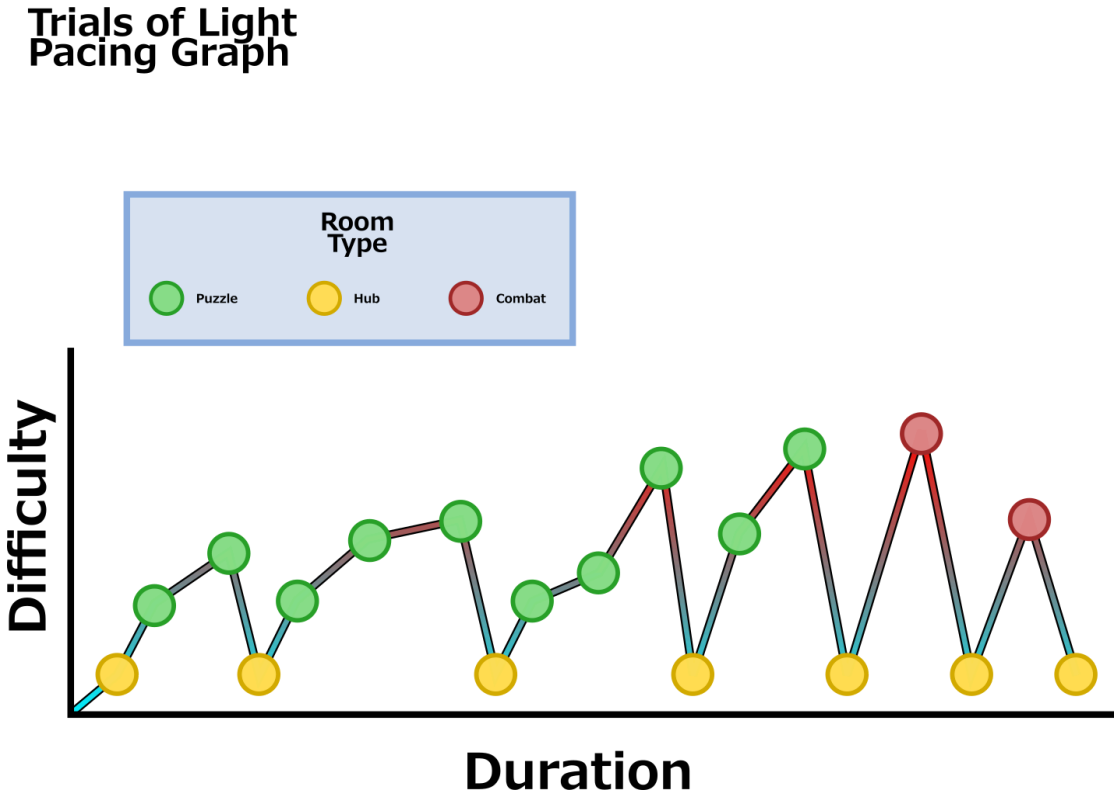
Section 4
Challenge Types: Timing, Time Limit, Logic
Puzzle Types: Fairy Bow, Longshot, Mirror Shield



Bubble Map



Pacing Graph





Dynamics

Holistic Assessment

The player will develop a tendency to associate a string of actions with the overarching puzzle rather than focusing on isolated actions with isolated solutions. Due to the more intricate puzzles that involve several components to consider, the player will begin to assess the full room and every mechanic involved while trying to solve the puzzle rooms.

The puzzle types and lack of enemies facilitates taking one's time to plan a solution. Therefore, the player will get used to planning a full solution as opposed to planning as they go. This reinforces the dungeon's theme of deeper logic puzzles.

Careful Execution

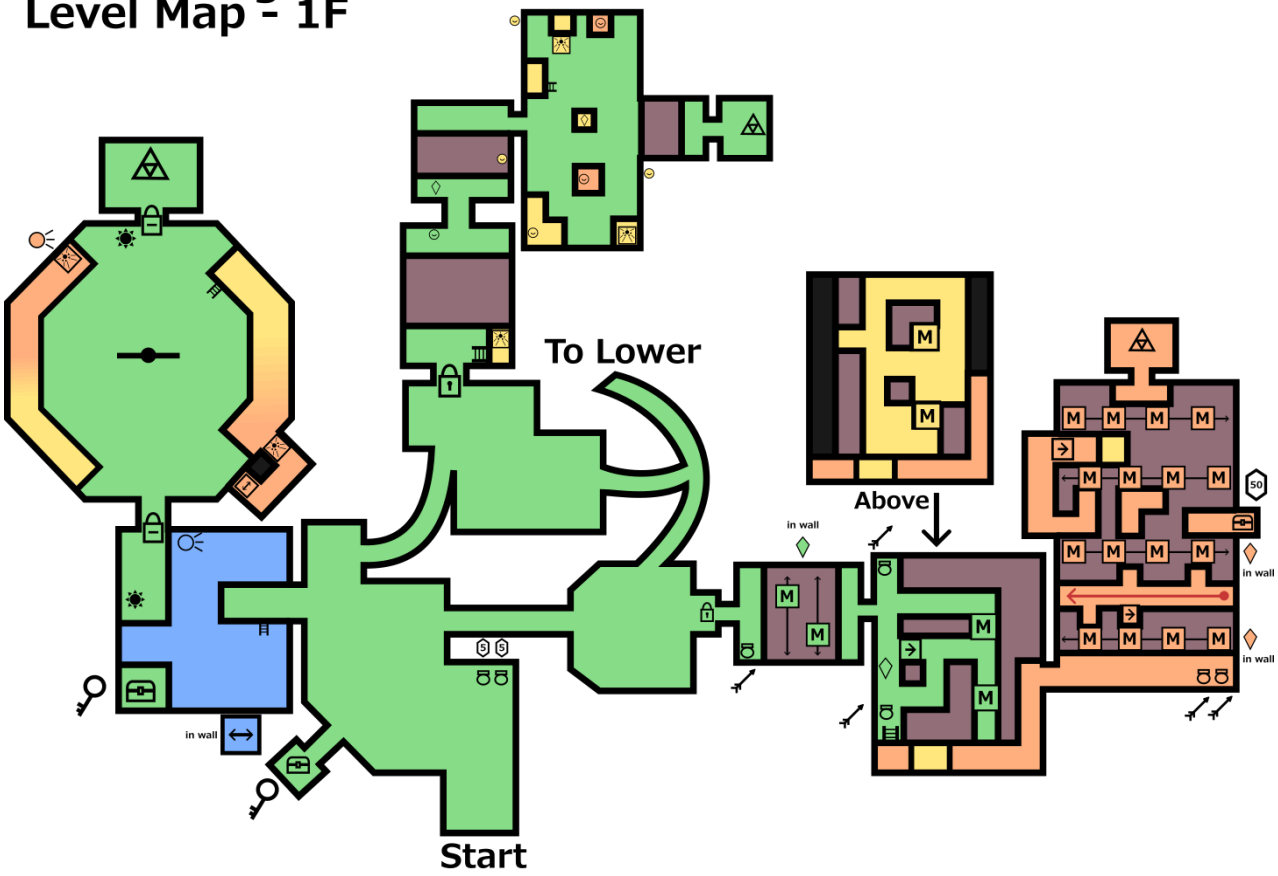
The player will learn to focus on being careful and precise when performing various actions related to the puzzles within the dungeon. The time-based challenges will necessitate more intentionality with the player's actions as they will need to be fast without making mistakes or be precise and accurate with their timing.

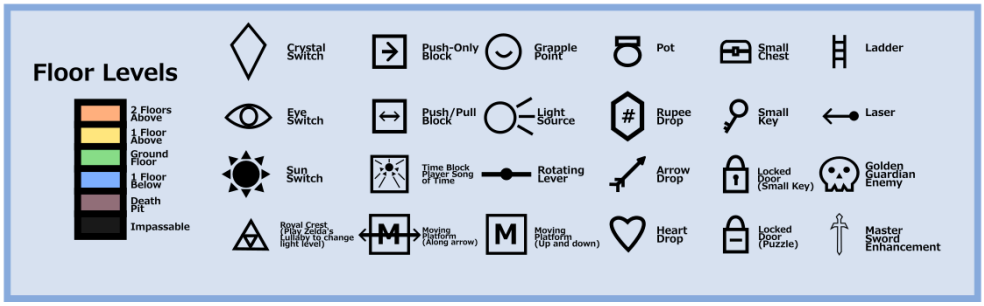
With larger and more intricate puzzle rooms that include multiple components, players might have to redo a fair amount of setup if they are reckless and make a mistake. Since time cannot be wasted on missed shots or extra setup, players will start to make more careful use of their items. The lack of external pressures from enemies or hazards will allow players to focus on accuracy of their actions.



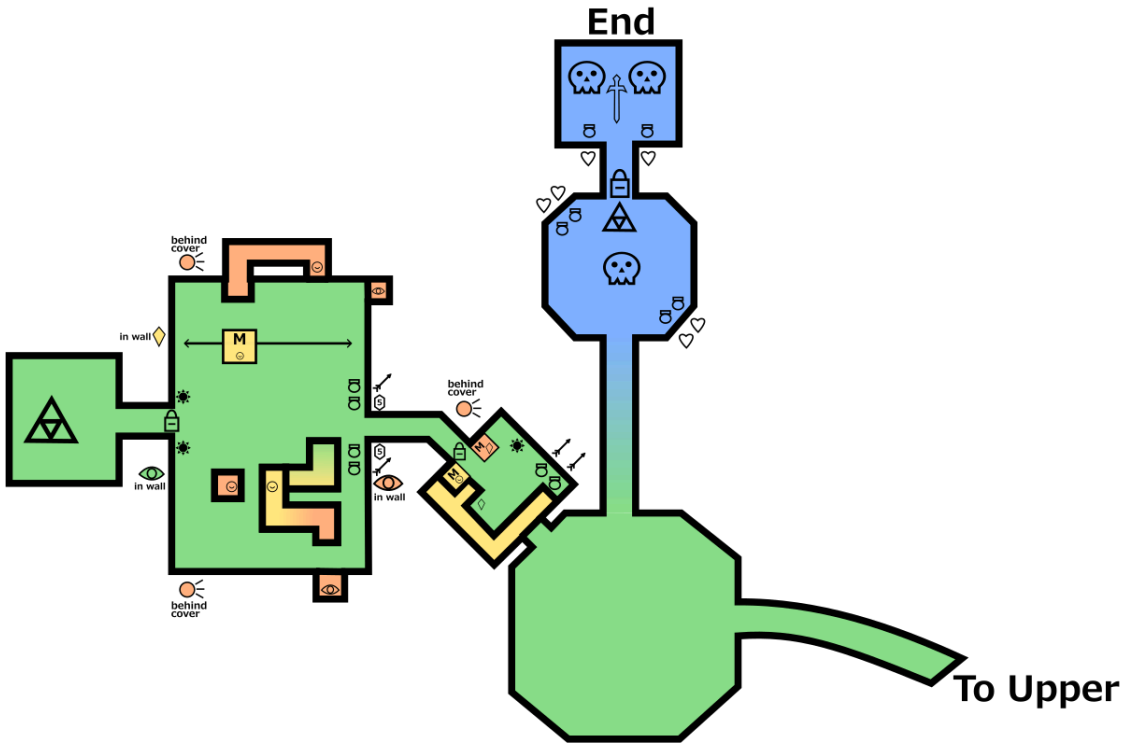
Level Map

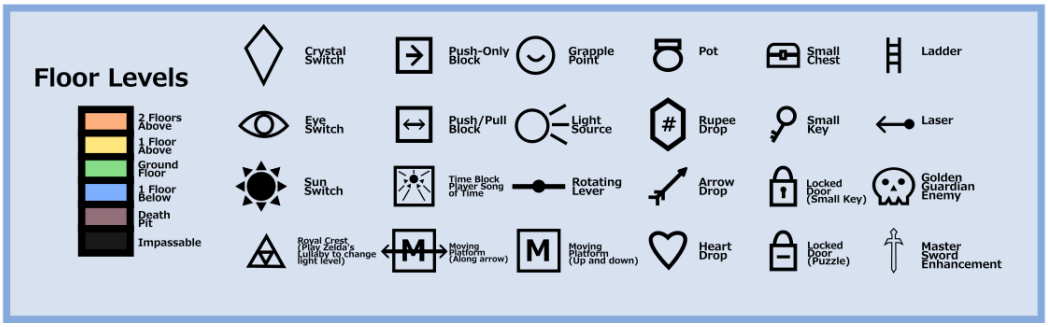
Trials of Light
Level Map - 1F





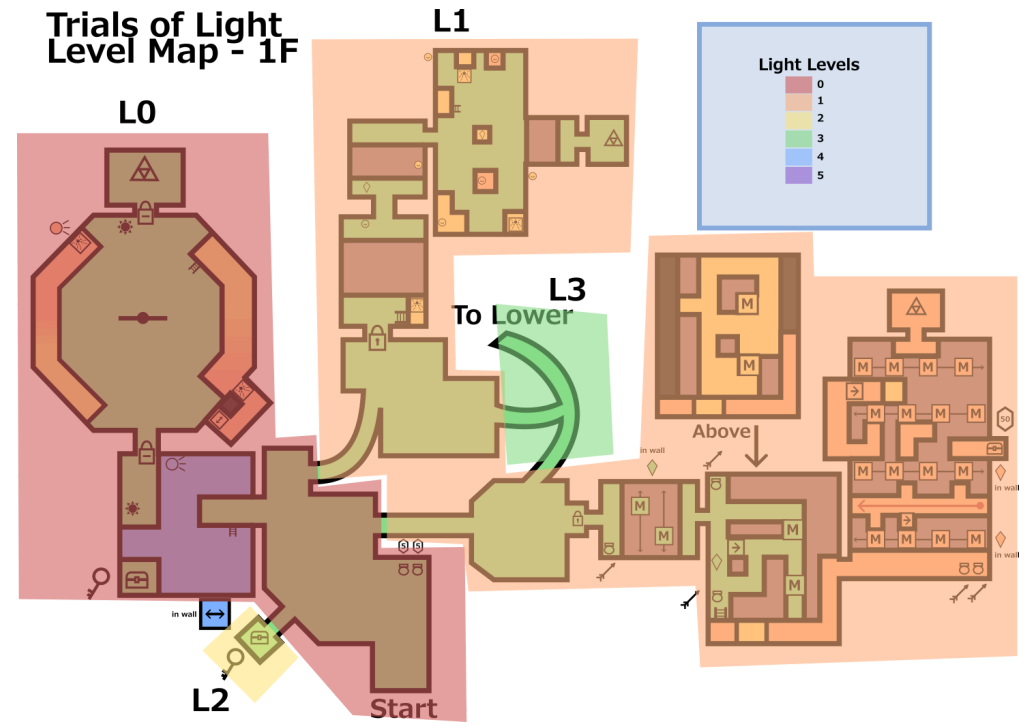
Trials of Light
Level Map - B1

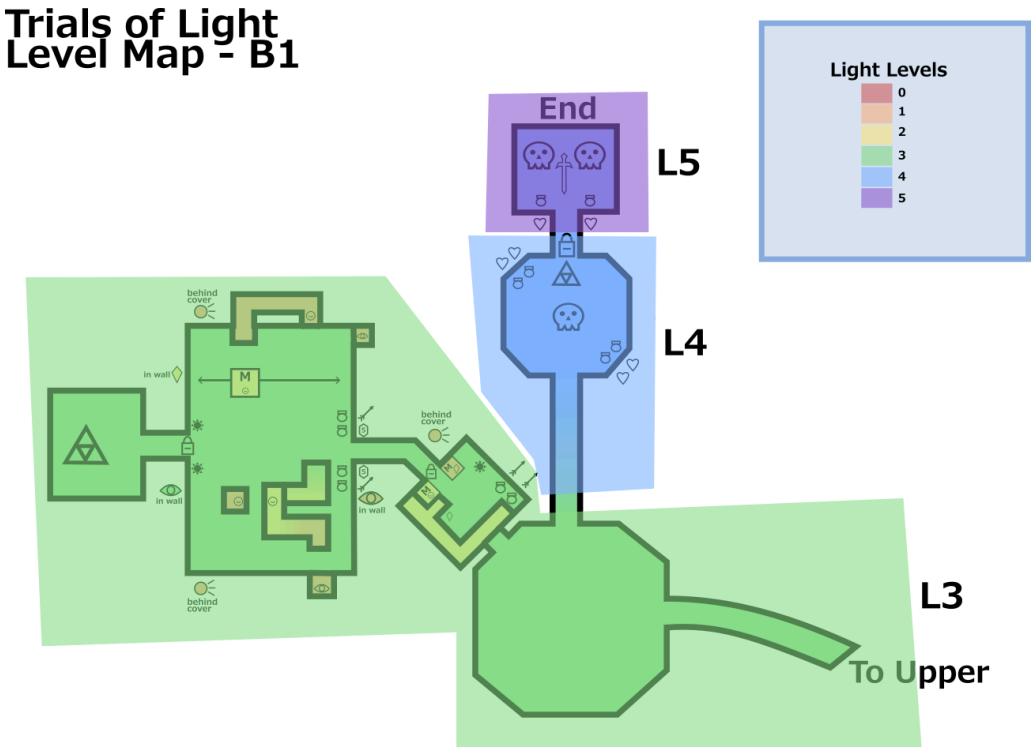




Light Levels

Each major section ends with the light level rising by one. Certain parts of the dungeon are only accessible once the associated light level has been reached.

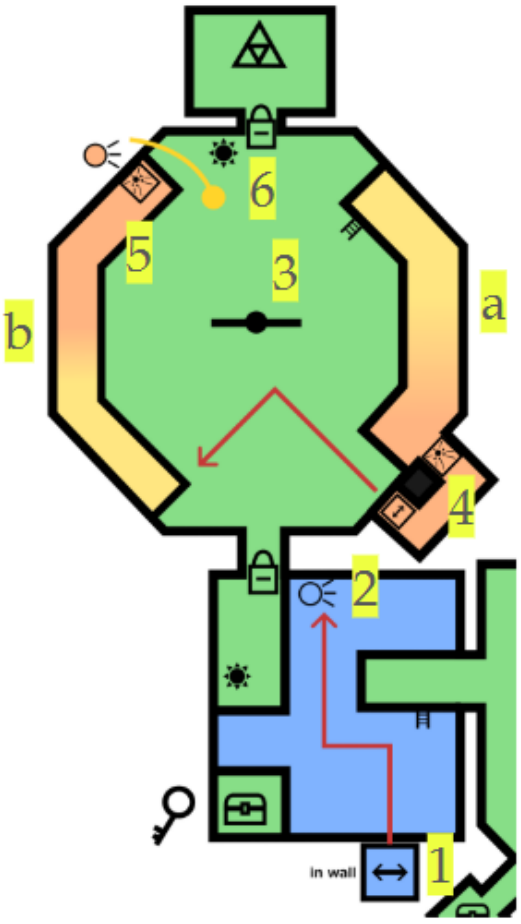




Section Overview

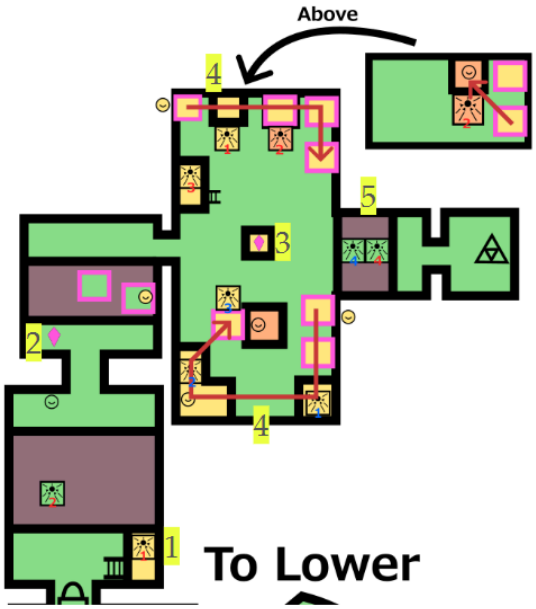
Section 1

1. Pull the block out from the wall and move it towards where the light hits the ground.
2. Stand on top of the block and reflect the light onto the sun switch to open the door.
3. Rotating lever which alters the room between two states
    a. Right segment is pulled out of wall and left segment is set in wall
    b. Left segment is pulled out of wall and right segment is set in wall
4. Climb right segment. Remove the time block with Song of Time. Push the other block onto the ground floor.
5. Push block and climb it to access the left segment. Remove the time block with Song of Time, revealing the light source.
6. Reflect light onto sun switch to open door.



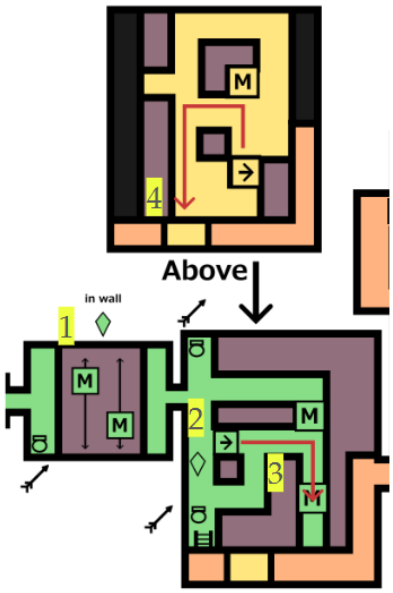
Section 2

1. Climb up the ladder, play Song of Time to move the time block from position 1 to position 2. Grapple to the other side.
2. Hit crystal to spawn platforms for a short time. Grapple to land on one, then platform to exit.
3. Hit crystal to spawn platforms around the room for a short time.
4. In both segments, grapple and platform to reach the time blocks. Play the Song of Time to move them to their next positions (1 -> 2 -> 3 -> 4).
5. Once both time blocks are at position 4, use them to reach the end of the room.

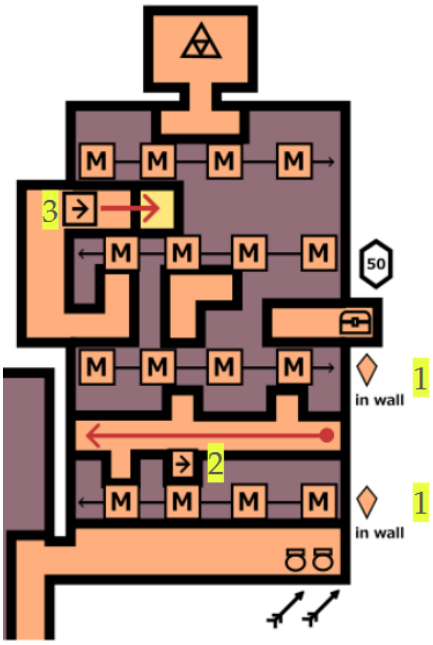


Section 3

1. Hit the crystal in the wall to stop the moving platforms and use them to reach the end of the room.
2. Hit the crystal to raise the moving platforms up one level or lower them down one level.
3. Push the block along the path, stop on the moving block and hit the crystal to bring it to the upper level.
4. Push the block into the side of the room to use as a platform to reach the end of the room.

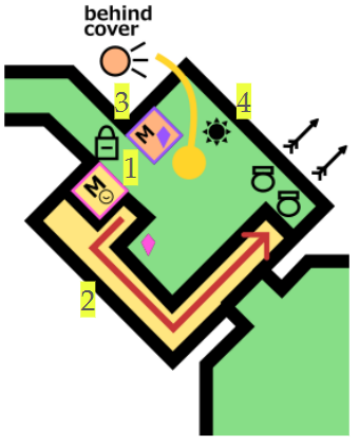


1. Hit the crystals in the wall to stop the moving platforms in front of them.
2. Push the block up to use as cover for the laser. Platform across the room.
3. Use the platforms to go around and push the block onto a lower level. Use the block to platform to the end of the room.

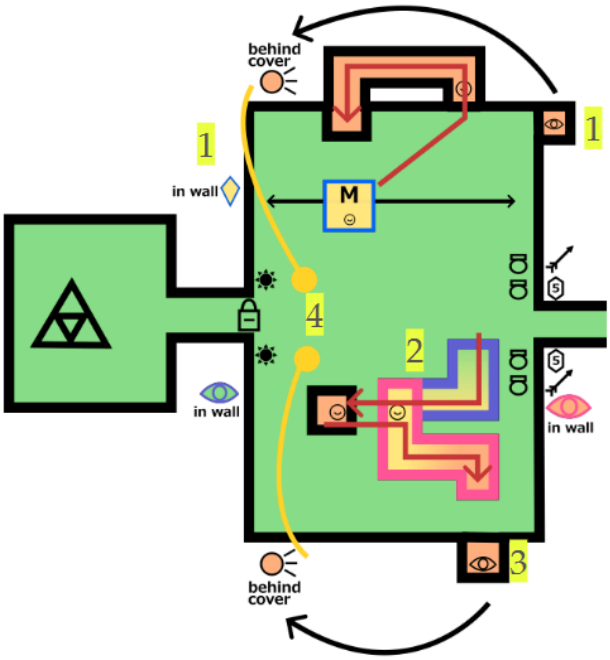


Section 4

1. Two pillars moving up and down. Hit the pink crystal to stop the left pillar. Hit the purple crystal to stop the right pillar. The purple crystal rests atop the designated pillar.
2. Stop the left pillar to be able to grapple onto it and walk around the upper level.
3. Stop the right pillar in the right spot to allow the light to shine through.
4. Reflect the light onto the sun switch to open the door.



1. Hit the crystal to stop the moving block for a short time. Grapple up and around to hit the eye switch, removing the cover for the first light source.
2. Two platforms embedded in the ground. Designated eye switches will raise them above ground for a short time.
3. Raise the purple platform and grapple to the upper platform. Hit the pink eye to raise the pink platform. Use the pink platform to hit the eye switch to remove the cover for the second light source.
4. Reflect each light source onto the nearest sun switch to open the door.



Section 5

1. Receive the Master Sword enhancement.
2. Two golden guardians will spawn into the room after the Master Sword is enhanced.

